DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

God's Longing for Israel and the Unity of Creation

Daat Tevunot §128-130

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §128-130
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Wednesday 31 May 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The question we are answering

We are in the second part of Section 6. The first part dealt with the levels of man before and after the sin. The second part deals with the second kind of "bad": that nothing physical lasts forever. The question is why. Why should the sin lead to everything physical coming to an end?

The Rabbi repeated an important point first. This applies only to the physical world after the sin. Gan Eden was physical too, with real trees and fruit, "whether grapes, apples or etrogim", but that level of physicality would have lasted forever.

Kavod and the interconnected world

The Ramhal (§128) returns to the saying of Hazal that everything Hashem created, He created for His kavod. As explained on Monday, kavod is itself something Hashem created. He made it possible for us to give Him honour, just as He made it possible for us to bring a "pleasing aroma".

Once we understand kavod, we understand how all of creation fits together. Each creature reveals a small part of Hashem's glory, but the full picture only appears when everything is seen together. So the perfection of any one thing depends on the perfection of everything else. If things are bound up with one another, none of them can be complete while the others are lacking.

One participant asked whether man-made extinctions are therefore a greater disaster than we think. The Rabbi agreed: hunting a species to extinction breaks into the structure of the whole system. Whether climate change counts as man-made in this sense, he said he was not sure.

Imperfection is disconnection

The Ramhal's principle is that nothing complete can be bad. All bad and all imperfection come from things not being properly linked. What one part lacks is supplied by another, and when everything is joined up we see that Hashem made it perfect.

A discussion followed. If imperfect things will be destroyed anyway, should we try to remove them? The Rabbi answered carefully. Everything Hashem made is good in its essence, and we must never think of destroying something because it seems bad to us. He gave the example of a body with clogged arteries. The body is not bad. The blockage is what harms the whole system, and when it is cleared everything flows again. Our good and bad deeds work the same way on the spiritual system.

So at the beginning Hashem made each species separately, each with its own role, and that separateness is what makes destruction possible. Linking them together is the tikkun, and it lifts them out of their bad. The Rabbi noted that this is really the Yihud of Hashem: when everything is joined, it becomes one, and oneness is perfection. Things end because the whole is not yet joined.

Why Israel?

In §129 the Neshamah asks: you promised to explain how Israel are precious. What do they have to do with this interconnected system?

The Sekhel answers (§130) that every change in the divine flow depends on Israel. Hashem relates to us like a father to a son and like a man to the wife of his youth. The Ramhal uses strong words. Teshukah is not just love but longing. He wants, as it were, to delight in us and rejoice with us, and when He turns towards us in love He wants to give more and more good, like a father who is always thinking about his children.

The Rabbi brought the Rambam in Hilchot Teshuvah, chapter 10, who describes the highest love of Hashem as being like someone lovesick. He told the story in the Gemara of a man who became physically ill from desire for a woman. The doctors said he would be cured if he could just speak to her from behind a fence. The Hakhamim refused even that. The point is how strong that kind of love is, and this is the love we are meant to have for Hashem.

The universe exists because Hashem is thinking about it

The Rabbi said this paragraph is the source of an analogy he has often used. Close your eyes and imagine a whole universe, with the strangest creatures you can think of. The moment the phone rings, it vanishes. It exists only while you are thinking about it.

So too the world exists because Hashem "thinks about it". There are degrees of attention. You can be fixed on something, or you can have it in the back of your mind while you do other things. When Hashem, as it were, turns His attention away, that is hester panim, and that is the source of bad. The more He is focused on the world, the more good flows. Since the world was created for Israel, all these changes in the flow depend on Israel.

Sin, said the Ramhal, makes Hashem turn away, "like a husband upset with his wife". The good deeds of the saddikim bring joy above and draw down good, and the deeds of the wicked cause the turning away. Hashem foresaw both from the start and built the system around them.

The Rabbi brought the saying of the Hafes Hayim that one should follow the news. Nothing happens in the world at random, and whatever happens in Thailand or Japan has something in it for us to learn.

Summary

- Everything is created for Hashem's kavod, and that kavod only appears fully when all of creation is seen as one connected system.
- Imperfection and destruction come from disconnection. Joining the parts together is the tikkun, and it is an expression of Yihud.
- Hashem's relationship to Israel is one of longing, like a father to a son and a husband to a young wife.
- The world exists because Hashem is, as it were, thinking about it. When His attention is focused there is good, and when He turns away there is hester and bad.
- The flow of good and bad in the world depends on the deeds of Israel. How the two ideas connect is left for the next class.

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